

Northwind Technologies - IT Security Policy

1. Purpose and Scope

This policy applies to all employees, contractors and interns who access Northwind systems or data, on company-issued or personal devices.

2. Password Requirements

Passwords must be at least 14 characters long and include upper case letters, lower case letters, numbers and at least one symbol. Passwords must be rotated every 90 days and the previous five passwords may not be reused. Sharing passwords with anyone, including IT staff, is prohibited. All employees must use the company password manager, 1Password, to store work credentials.

3. Multi-Factor Authentication

Multi-factor authentication is mandatory for email, the VPN, the code repository and all cloud consoles. Hardware security keys are issued to engineering and finance staff. SMS-based codes are not permitted as a second factor because they are vulnerable to SIM swapping.

4. Remote Access and VPN

Access to internal systems from outside the office requires the Northwind VPN. Public Wi-Fi may be used only with the VPN active. VPN sessions automatically disconnect after 12 hours and after 30 minutes of inactivity.

5. Device Security

All laptops must have full-disk encryption enabled and the screen must lock after 5 minutes of inactivity. Company data may not be stored on personal USB drives. Lost or stolen devices must be reported to security@northwind.example within 2 hours of discovery.

6. Data Classification

Data is classified as Public, Internal, Confidential or Restricted. Customer personal data and financial records are always Restricted. Restricted data may not be copied to personal devices, pasted into third-party AI tools, or emailed outside the company without written approval from the Data Protection Officer.

7. Incident Reporting

Suspected phishing emails must be forwarded to phishing@northwind.example and then deleted. Any suspected breach must be reported immediately; the security team aims to acknowledge reports within 1 hour during business hours and within 4 hours outside them.